

The Best Data Storage and Back-Up Device For You

As data grows, so do the options for storing data. There is a wide range of data storage and back-up devices available in the market today, but choosing the right option based on your needs could be a difficult task. We spoke to some tech experts and chalked out a few criteria that could form the basis of your selection the next time you are buying a storage or backup device to preserve your data



DIKSHA P GUPTA

If you are amongst those who store almost everything you need on your computer, data storage and back-up devices are a must for you. Whether it is your music collection, your favourite movies or your data records, you cannot depend on your computer hard disk to save all of that for you. One cannot deny that even the best of computers can crash. So having a backup of your files is a good idea.

Determine your needs

The first thing you should do before looking to buy a data storage and backup device is determine your needs. This can be easily done by answering the following three questions:

1. How much of data needs to be stored?
2. How portable does your storage need to be?
3. What are your future storage needs likely to be?

After you are clear about these three aspects, you are almost there with respect to determining your data needs. Data storage devices are assessed on the basis of the capacity that they provide. Modern-day storage devices are available in terms of megabytes (MB), gigabytes (GB) and terabytes (TB). A 1TB drive can easily store about 284,000 digital photographs or 250,000 songs. With the evolution

of the market and increasing data storage needs, one can expect a storage device with petabyte capacity very soon. For simply transferring data files from one computer to the other, a smaller memory device is an apt choice, but for storing the data over a longer period of time, it is advisable to choose a bigger memory device, which can copy the contents of your computer with just a click.

Unsure about how much of data you need to store? Just right click on the folder where the data is saved, click on 'Properties,' and the pop-up box appearing thereafter will tell you the file size. If you are working on a Mac, right click the 'Document' folder and click 'Get info.'

The best device for you

So, once you know how much data you have to store, you can choose from a variety of storage options available in the market. Broadly, current data storage options can be classified into two categories: local storage options and remote storage options. The former includes everything that you can physically access, including the USB drive and the hard drives; while remote data storage options are cloud-based. We will discuss some of the popular local data storage options here.

1. USB sticks. These are the easiest portable options that can fit even in your key chain. You can find USB sticks having 1GB to 128GB storage capacity. They are small in size and, by virtue of not having any movable parts, are pretty robust. The makers of USB drives have also started covering the drives with steel to make them even sturdier. One major disadvantage of the USB drives is that they are relatively expensive compared to other storage options. Hence, it is advisable that you buy a USB drive for data transfer purposes or to back up small amounts of data only. Also, since they are frequently used, they are always at risk of picking up viruses from a computer and spreading them to the others.

2. External hard drives. External hard drives are pretty similar to those used with a computer, with the only difference being that they can be plugged into the computer or removed as per your needs. External hard drives are typically available in two sizes: a 8.9cm (3.5-inch) device known as the desktop external hard drive and a 6.4cm (2.5-inch) device known as a portable external hard drive.